

An early monsoon and the urban planning challenge

The monsoon arrived in Kerala on Sunday, more than a week before schedule. It took a day to **advance** towards Maharashtra, and reached Mumbai on Monday, 16 days before its expected arrival — the earliest **onset** of the season in at least 75 years. **Normal life** in the city, which has experienced its wettest May in the past 107 years, **was thrown off** gear. Its **low-lying** areas were **inundated**, public transport was badly hit, and **uprooted** trees **aggravated** traffic **snarls**. Much of the **disruption** was **admittedly** because the **downpour** was **unanticipated**. The city's municipality had set a deadline of June 7 to complete the **desilting** of drains. It was able to **undertake** a little more than 70 per cent of this task before the rains arrived.

Since the **catastrophic floods** of 2005, steps taken by the BMC — **widening** stormwater drains and adding pumping stations, **for instance** — **have** reduced the monsoon-related problems of Mumbaikars **to an extent**. However, the BRIMSTOWAD **project**, initiated to **overhaul** the city's drainage system after 2005 tragedy, **remains** incomplete. Designed more than 150 years ago to **deal with** 25 mm of rainfall per hour, spread out through the monsoon season, the city's drainage system is **ill-equipped** to deal with the recent changes in weather patterns — relatively short but intense **downpours**. On Monday, for instance, several parts of Mumbai received 170 mm to 250 mm rain. The problem gets **compounded** because the **catchment areas** of some of the natural water bodies — the Mithi River, for instance — **have** been taken over by real estate. Reclaiming this land might be difficult. However, stopping garbage dumping into water bodies could substantially improve their health — and ability to absorb the rains.

Several **parts** of the country **have** experienced an unusually wet summer this year. Last week, Bengaluru was **battered** by rainfall. Like Mumbai, Karnataka's capital, too, hasn't invested much in drainage overhaul, and the city has lost most of its lakes. Similarly, **Delhi**, which has received nine times the normal rainfall in May, **hasn't revamped** its drainage system since 1976. The crisis speaks of a governance crisis, even though the municipalities of Mumbai, Delhi, and Bengaluru are amongst the country's richest. It's time they — and their **counterparts** in other parts of the country — recognised that dealing with weather **vagaries** is a key part of their **mandate**. Flooding and **waterlogging** incidents are not **irritants** — these hurt the economy, affect people's **livelihoods** and **claim** lives. **[Practice Ex.]**

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

Vocabulary

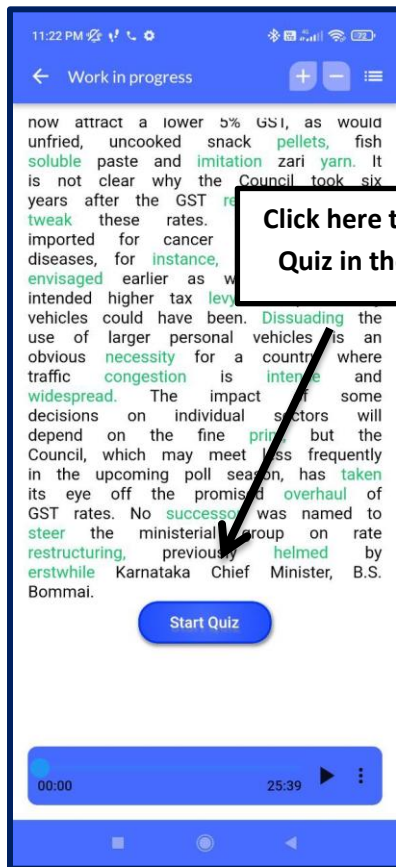
1. **Advance** (verb) – proceed, move forward, progress, approach, go ahead आगे बढ़ना
2. **Onset** (noun) – beginning, start, arrival, initiation, commencement शुरुआत
3. **Throw off** (phrasal verb) – disrupt, disorganize, disturb, unbalance, unsettle बाधित करना
4. **Low-lying** (adjective) – below sea level, flat, shallow, depressed, sunken नीचाई वाला
5. **Inundate** (verb) – flood, submerge, overwhelm, drown, deluge जलमग्न करना
6. **Uproot** (verb) – displace, remove, pull out, extract, unseat उखाड़ देना
7. **Aggravate** (verb) – worsen, intensify, escalate, heighten, exacerbate बिगाड़ना / बढ़ाना
8. **Snarl** (noun) – traffic jam, tangle, obstruction, clog, congestion ट्रैफिक जाम
9. **Disruption** (noun) – disturbance, interruption, breakdown, chaos, interference अव्यवस्था / बाधा
10. **Admittedly** (adverb) – unquestionably, indeed, in fact, it is true, granted यह मानते हुए
11. **Downpour** (noun) – heavy rain, deluge, cloudburst, torrential rain, rainfall मूसलधार वर्षा
12. **Unanticipated** (adjective) – unexpected, unforeseen, surprising, unpredicted, unplanned अनपेक्षित
13. **Desilting** (noun) – removal of silt, clearing, dredging, unclogging, cleaning गाद हटाना
14. **Undertake** (verb) – begin, start, initiate, perform, assume करना / कार्य आरंभ करना
15. **Catastrophic** (adjective) – disastrous, devastating, calamitous, ruinous, tragic विनाशकारी
16. **Widen** (verb) – broaden, expand, enlarge, extend, increase चौड़ा करना
17. **For instance** (phrase) – for example, such as, to illustrate, like, namely उदाहरण के लिए
18. **To an extent** (phrase) – partially, somewhat, in part, moderately, up to a point कुछ हद तक
19. **Overhaul** (verb) – revamp, renovate, reform, reconstruct, improve मरम्मत करना
20. **Deal with** (phrasal verb) – handle, manage, address, tackle, confront निपटना

21. **Ill-equipped** (adjective) – unprepared, underprepared, inadequate, unfit, lacking
तैयार न होना
22. **Downpour** (noun) – (duplicate) heavy rain, deluge, cloudburst मूसलधार बारिश
23. **Compound** (verb) – worsen, intensify, magnify, heighten, aggravate और अधिक बढ़ाना
24. **Catchment area** (noun) – the area from which rainfall flows into a river, lake, or reservoir. जलग्रहण क्षेत्र
25. **Batter** (verb) – pummel, strike, pound, thrash, beat प्रहार करना
26. **Revamp** (verb) – renovate, restructure, renew, modernize, reform पुनर्निर्माण करना
27. **Counterpart** (noun) – equivalent, peer, opposite number, fellow, match समकक्ष
28. **Vagary** (noun) – unpredictability, fluctuation, whim, inconsistency, quirk अनिश्चितता
29. **Mandate** (noun) – directive, authority, order, command, authorization आदेश / दायित्व
30. **Waterlogging** (noun) – flooding, saturation, inundation, swampiness, oversaturation जलभराव
31. **Irritant** (noun) – annoyance, nuisance, disturbance, bother, aggravation परेशानी / झंझट
32. **Livelihood** (noun) – income, occupation, means of living, subsistence, employment आजीविका
33. **Claim** (verb) – take, demand, seize, cause the loss of, require जान लेना

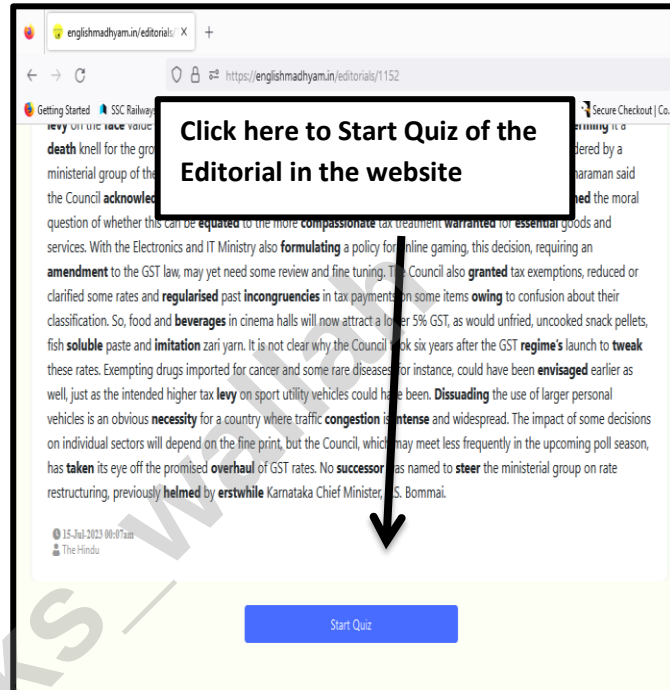
Summary of the Editorial

1. **Early Monsoon Arrival:** The monsoon arrived in Kerala and Mumbai significantly earlier than expected, with Mumbai witnessing its earliest onset in 75 years.
2. **Record Rainfall:** Mumbai experienced its wettest May in 107 years, with rainfall between 170 mm to 250 mm in some areas.
3. **Urban Disruption:** The intense and unexpected rain caused widespread disruption — waterlogging, traffic jams, and public transport paralysis.
4. **Incomplete Preparation:** Only around 70% of drain desilting in Mumbai was completed before the rains, missing the planned June 7 deadline.
5. **Legacy of 2005 Floods:** Post-2005 flood measures, such as widening drains and building pumping stations, helped but were not sufficient.
6. **BRIMSTOWAD Delay:** The key drainage improvement project remains unfinished, highlighting lapses in long-term infrastructure upgrades.
7. **Outdated Infrastructure:** Mumbai's drainage system, designed over 150 years ago for lower rain intensity, is unable to handle today's heavy downpours.
8. **Encroachment of Catchment Areas:** Real estate developments have taken over natural catchment areas, such as those of the Mithi River.
9. **Garbage Dumping Issue:** Continued waste dumping in water bodies weakens their capacity to manage rainwater.
10. **Bengaluru's Struggle:** The city was hit by heavy rains but lacks significant investment in drainage; most of its lakes have vanished.
11. **Delhi's Neglect:** Delhi, which saw nine times its usual May rainfall, has not updated its drainage system since 1976.
12. **Nationwide Pattern:** Several Indian cities are facing the consequences of inadequate drainage and urban planning amid erratic weather.
13. **Wealthy But Inefficient:** Despite being among India's richest municipalities, Mumbai, Delhi, and Bengaluru show poor preparedness.
14. **Governance Failure:** The flooding crisis reflects a deeper governance and planning failure in handling environmental changes.
15. **Urgent Need for Urban Reform:** Authorities must treat flood management as a priority to protect lives, livelihoods, and the economy.

Practice Exercise: Banking Pattern Based



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